

MODDABLE CHESS · VARIANT 15 OF 70

# Courier Chess

**12×8**  
BOARD

**2**  
PLAYERS

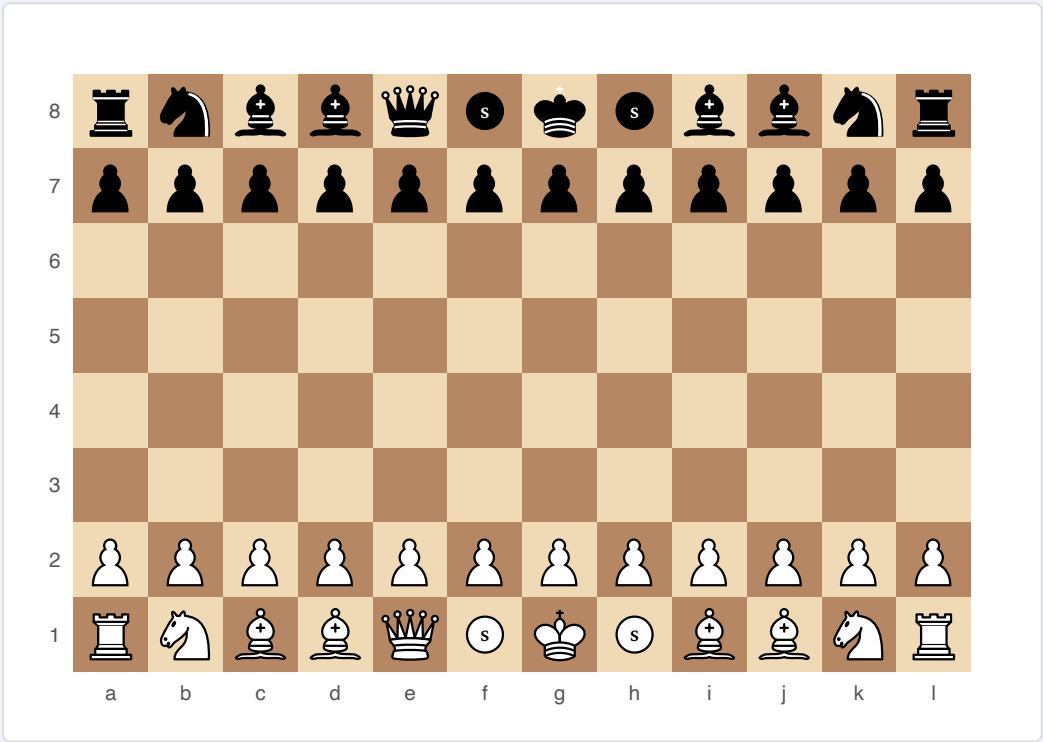
# COURIER CHESS

A medieval large-board variant documented since 1202, predating the modern Queen and Bishop moves. One of the oldest recorded chess variants in Europe.

SETUP

**Board:** 12×8 (96 squares).

**FEN:** rnbbqsksbbr/pppppppppppp/12/12/12/12/PPPPPPPPPPP/RNBBQSKSBBNR w - - 0 1



Courier Chess — starting position (12×8)

**Pieces (per side, from a-file):** Rook, Knight, Elephant, Courier, Sage, King, General, Courier, Elephant, Knight, Rook, Rook. 12 Pawns on the second rank.

| PIECE            | MOVEMENT                                                                         |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| King             | One step any direction (as standard)                                             |
| General          | One step diagonally only (precursor to Queen — very weak)                        |
| Courier          | Slides diagonally any distance (modern Bishop)                                   |
| Sage (Schleich)  | One step in any direction (same as King, but not royal)                          |
| Elephant (Alfil) | Exactly two steps diagonally, jumping over the intermediate square               |
| Rook             | Slides orthogonally (as standard)                                                |
| Knight           | L-shape jump (as standard)                                                       |
| Pawn             | One step forward, captures diagonally. No double-step. Promotes to General only. |

## RULES

Standard chess movement applies per the table above. No castling. No pawn double-step. No en passant. Stalemate counts as a win (medieval rules).

## WIN CONDITION

Checkmate or stalemate (stalemate = win for the side delivering it in medieval rules).

**Historical note:** The Courier was the first piece to move like a modern Bishop — this game introduced unlimited diagonal sliding to European chess centuries before it was adopted into the standard game.

## STRATEGY

The General (proto-Queen) is extremely weak — one diagonal step. The Couriers (modern Bishops) are the strongest attacking pieces. The wide board makes Knight development slow. Alfils (Elephants) can leap but are limited to every-other-square diagonals, creating gaps in coverage. Rooks dominate open files as in standard chess.

## ATTRIBUTION

First documented 1202 (Wirnt von Gravenberg). Public domain.